

Richard Carlile

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Richard Carlile was born on 9th December 1790 in Ashburton, Devon. His father deserted the family, which depended on the profits of a small shop. Richard received six years of free education from the local school and learnt to read and write. At the age of twelve, Richard left school and was apprenticed as a tinplate worker in Plymouth.

In 1813, Richard got married, and soon afterwards, the couple moved to London. Over the next few years, Jane Carlile gave birth to five children, three of whom survived. Richard found work as a tinsmith, but in the winter of 1816 his hours were reduced, creating serious economic problems for the family. Carlile began attending political meetings and heard radical speakers like Henry Hunt complain about a parliamentary system that only allowed three men in every hundred to vote. Carlile remembered the vicar of Ashburton condemning Tom Paine for advocating parliamentary reform.

Carlile decided to earn a living by becoming a publisher and selling the writings of Tom Paine in London. In 1817, he rented a shop in Fleet Street. He started by dividing *The Rights of Man* into sections to sell as small pamphlets. He also began a radical newspaper called *The Republican*. It reported on political meetings, book extracts and poems by supporters of the reform movement such as Shelley and Byron. Carlile's newspaper was very popular, and soon he was making £50 a week profit.

On 16th August 1819, Richard Carlile joined Henry Hunt on the platform at a meeting on parliamentary reform at St Peter's Fields in Manchester. The local magistrates ordered the yeomanry to break up the meeting. Eleven people were killed in what became known as the Peterloo Massacre. The next edition of the paper described how the military had charged the crowd and criticised the government for its role in the incident.



Richard Carlile (left); his offices at 62 Fleet Street with a tableau protesting against church tithes (right) Note bishop with devil in left first floor window.

The laws on seditious libel prohibited publications which might encourage people to be anti-government. The authorities also disapproved of Carlile publishing Tom Paine's *Age of Reason*, which was critical of the Church of England.

In October 1819, Carlile was found guilty of blasphemy and seditious libel and was sentenced to three years in Dorchester Gaol. His Fleet Street offices were raided and his stock confiscated. While he was in prison, he continued

to write material for the paper, now being published by his wife. Circulation increased dramatically as a result of the trial's publicity, and the paper was now outselling pro-government newspapers such as *The Times*.

In December 1819, the government imposed a 4 pence tax on cheap newspapers and stipulated that they could not be sold for less than 7 pence. As most working people earned less than 10 shillings a week, this severely reduced the number who could afford radical newspapers.

The government also continued prosecuting those involved in publishing radical newspapers. In 1821, Jane Carlile was sentenced to two years' imprisonment in Dorchester for seditious libel; their daughter, Hypatia, was born in prison. Jane was replaced by Richard Carlile's sister, Mary Carlile, but she too was imprisoned six months later. During the next few months, over 150 men and women were sent to prison for selling *The Republican*.

After leaving prison in 1825, Carlile returned to publishing newspapers. He was now a strong supporter of women's rights. His articles suggested that women should have the right to vote and be elected to Parliament. In 1826, he also published *Every Woman's Book*, which advocated birth control and the sexual emancipation of women.

In 1830, Carlile was back in prison for writing an article in support of agricultural labourers campaigning against wage cuts. When Carlile left prison two years later, he was deeply in debt and lived in extreme poverty. He died in 1843; a packed funeral recognised the important role he had played in achieving a free press.